

Pericles

Pericles (c. 495–429^{BCE}) became Athens' most famous democrat and the leading man of the city-state for about 30 years. He came to prominence around 462^{BCE}, when he helped the politician Ephialtes dismantle the Areopagus—the last bastion of oligarchic

control. After Ephialtes' death, Pericles undertook further reforms, including the introduction of pay for those serving in the courts, making it possible for even the poorest citizen to have his say. He is also believed to have helped drive Athens' assertive foreign policy as the city sought to exploit its dominance of the Delian League. During the 440s and 430s^{BCE}, Pericles

was involved in an ambitious public building program that provoked controversy at home, where he fought off revolt, and abroad, where he was condemned for requisitioning money from the Delian League to pay for the Parthenon. Nonetheless, he was popular and was elected as general every year from 443^{BCE}.

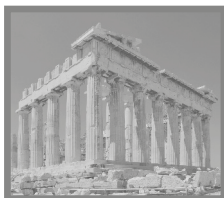
as land reform and debt slavery, threatened to lead to civil breakdown.

Solon and Cleisthenes

In Athens, some of these tensions were eased around 594^{BCE} by the reforms of the statesman Solon. He established a law that declared all citizens could vote in matters of state, and that a law court should admit all citizens. At the same time, however, he mollified the upper classes by introducing a graded oligarchy in which power corresponded to wealth—the aristocracy was to control the highest offices, the middle class the lesser offices, and the poor could be selected by lot to serve on juries.

In the late 6th century^{BCE}, Athens fell under the sway of the tyrant Pisistratus and his sons. In response, a faction of aristocrats led by Cleisthenes allied with lower-ranking members of society to take power. The institution of true democracy in Athens is traditionally dated to this point—around 507^{BCE}. Cleisthenes introduced true popular government, or direct democracy, enabling all citizens of Athens to vote directly on Athenian policy (unlike in a contemporary representative democracy, in which the

people elect representatives to act as the legislature). He also reorganized the citizenry into units by geography rather than kinship, breaking the traditional ties that underpinned Athenian aristocratic society, and established sortition—the random selection of citizens for government »



The Parthenon, built in 447–438^{BCE} as a temple dedicated to the goddess Athena, is often seen as a symbol of democracy and Western civilization.

